

Diabetic Retinopathy Diagnosis and Classification using Vision Transformer

Vanaja C^{1*}, Harikanth R^{1*}, Sabarinath A¹ and Naveenkumar S¹

Sri Manakula Vinayagar Engineering College, Madagadipet,
Puducherry 605107, India

Abstract

Diabetic Retinopathy (DR) is a leading cause of vision loss among diabetic patients, where early detection is crucial for preventing permanent damage. This work presents an automated DR diagnosis system using a Vision Transformer (ViT) model to analyze retinal fundus images. By processing images as patches and learning global relationships through self-attention, the proposed approach overcomes limitations of CNN-based models. The system classifies DR into five severity stages and incorporates attention-based explainability to highlight clinically relevant regions. The model is trained and evaluated on preprocessed retinal datasets using standard performance metrics such as accuracy, precision, recall, and F1-score. The results demonstrate improved accuracy, scalability, and interpretability, making the system suitable for reliable and early DR screening.

Keywords: Diabetic Retinopathy (DR), Vision Transformer (ViT), Convolution Neural Network (CNN)

I. Introduction

Diabetic Retinopathy (DR) is a diabetes-related retinal disorder and a major cause of preventable blindness, where early detection is crucial for effective treatment. Manual screening of retinal fundus images is time-consuming, subjective, and difficult to scale for large populations. Existing automated approaches primarily rely on Convolutional Neural Networks (CNNs), which improve detection accuracy but mainly focus on local image features, suffer from limited global context understanding, and provide restricted interpretability, reducing clinical trust and robustness across datasets.

ViT Diagnosis

To address these limitations, this implementation adopts a Vision Transformer (ViT)-based diagnostic framework for automated DR classification. The proposed approach divides retinal images into fixed-size patches and employs self-attention mechanisms to capture long-range dependencies and global retinal patterns. The model classifies images into five DR severity stages and integrates attention-based explainability to highlight clinically relevant regions. This solution enhances diagnostic accuracy, scalability, and transparency, making it suitable for reliable early DR screening and clinical decision support.

II. Related work

Diabetic Retinopathy (DR) detection has significantly advanced with the integration of Artificial Intelligence (AI) and Deep Learning (DL) techniques. Traditional ophthalmic diagnosis often depends on manual examination of retinal fundus images, which can lead to inconsistent interpretation and delayed detection of disease severity. To address these limitations, Computer-Aided Diagnosis (CAD) systems based on deep learning have been widely developed to assist clinicians in early and accurate DR detection [12]. Early approaches primarily employed Convolutional Neural Networks (CNNs) for feature extraction and classification of retinal lesions such as microaneurysms, hemorrhages, and exudates. These models demonstrated promising performance in automated DR screening, although they faced challenges related to dataset imbalance and limited interpretability [10], [11].

To improve model transparency and clinical trust, Explainable Artificial Intelligence (XAI) techniques such as Grad-CAM and LIME have been integrated with CNN architectures. These methods highlight pathological regions in retinal images and provide visual explanations for model predictions, enhancing interpretability for medical practitioners [1], [4]. Furthermore, ensemble deep learning approaches combining architectures such as VGG19, ResNet50, and InceptionV3 have shown superior performance by capturing multi-scale and complex retinal features, achieving classification accuracy exceeding 98–99% on benchmark datasets [2], [3], [8].

Recent research has also explored advanced deep learning architectures and large-scale datasets to improve DR grading accuracy. Studies using extensive fundus image datasets and pre-trained networks such as DenseNet, MobileNet, and EfficientNet have demonstrated improved feature learning and computational efficiency, although multi-class classification of DR severity remains challenging due to class imbalance and subtle lesion variations [6], [13]. Additionally, systematic surveys highlight that deep learning models generally outperform traditional machine learning methods such as Support Vector Machines and Random Forests in DR detection tasks [7], [14].

Beyond diagnostic accuracy, recent work has emphasized data privacy and secure medical AI systems. Privacy-preserving frameworks using encryption techniques, federated learning, blockchain integration, and differential privacy have been proposed to ensure secure handling of sensitive patient data while maintaining model performance [5], [9], [15]. These approaches are particularly important for large-scale healthcare deployments where patient confidentiality and regulatory compliance are critical.

Overall, recent studies demonstrate that AI-driven DR detection systems have achieved significant improvements in accuracy, interpretability, and clinical applicability. However, challenges such as dataset diversity, class imbalance, privacy protection, and real-

world clinical validation remain open research areas that continue to drive advancements in automated retinal disease diagnosis.

III. Proposed Method

Conventional deep learning approaches for diabetic retinopathy diagnosis predominantly rely on Convolutional Neural Networks (CNNs), which extract features through convolution and pooling operations. While effective in detecting localized retinal abnormalities such as microaneurysms and hemorrhages, these models exhibit limitations in capturing global retinal context and long-range feature dependencies. Furthermore, CNN-based systems often provide limited interpretability and face scalability challenges when applied to high-resolution fundus images, restricting their reliability in large-scale clinical screening.

To overcome these limitations, this work adopts a Vision Transformer (ViT)–based deep learning framework for diabetic retinopathy classification. Vision Transformers divide retinal images into fixed-size patches and convert them into embedded representations with positional information. These patch embeddings are processed through transformer encoder layers using multi-head self-attention, enabling the model to learn both global and local retinal relationships. In this implementation, preprocessed fundus images are classified into five diabetic retinopathy severity stages. Attention-based visualizations are also utilized to highlight diagnostically significant retinal regions, improving model transparency, accuracy, and clinical usability.

Architecture Diagram

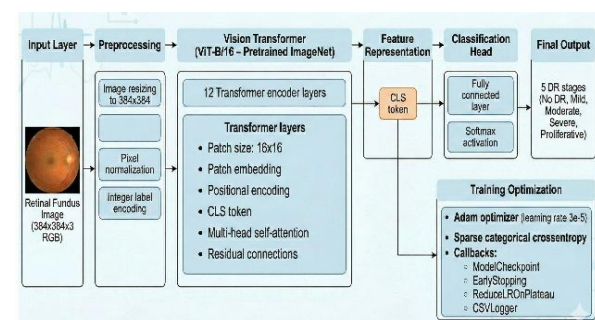


Fig.1 Architecture of system

The proposed system follows an end-to-end Vision Transformer-based architecture for diabetic retinopathy diagnosis, as illustrated in Fig. 1. Initially, retinal fundus images undergo preprocessing to ensure consistent resolution and normalized pixel distributions. The processed data is then transformed into suitable feature representations for effective learning. Subsequently, the Vision Transformer model is constructed and trained using optimized parameters. After training, the model is evaluated using unseen test data, and the final output provides predictions of diabetic retinopathy severity levels.

Data collection

The dataset used in this implementation consists of retinal fundus images representing a wide range of diabetic retinopathy conditions, including normal retinas and various pathological stages. The images capture clinically significant retinal structures such as the optic disc, blood vessels, macula, microaneurysms, hemorrhages, hard exudates, and neovascular regions. These visual characteristics are critical indicators for grading diabetic retinopathy severity and form the foundation for automated diagnosis.

The dataset includes images with varying illumination, contrast levels, and noise conditions, closely reflecting real-world clinical scenarios. Some images exhibit dense lesion regions and blurred vascular patterns, while others show subtle early-stage abnormalities, as illustrated in Fig. 2. This variability is essential for training a robust Vision Transformer model, as it encourages the learning of generalized feature representations rather than dataset-specific patterns. The presence of both mild and severe cases helps the model distinguish fine-grained severity transitions, which is a key requirement for accurate clinical grading. In addition, the dataset contains diverse retinal structures, including variations in blood vessel thickness, microaneurysms, hemorrhages, and exudates, enabling the model to capture complex pathological features associated with diabetic retinopathy. Such diversity improves the model's ability to handle unseen clinical data

and enhances its generalization capability across different patient populations. Consequently, the dataset supports the development of a reliable automated screening system capable of assisting ophthalmologists in early detection and severity assessment of diabetic retinopathy.

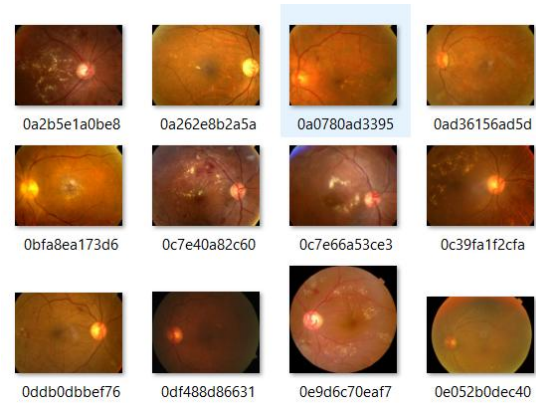


Fig.2 Data Collection

From an implementation perspective, these dataset characteristics directly support the effectiveness of the Vision Transformer architecture. By dividing images into patches, the model learns spatial relationships between distant retinal regions, such as correlations between peripheral lesions and central macular changes. This global-context learning is particularly beneficial for identifying proliferative diabetic retinopathy, where abnormalities are distributed across the retina.

Pre-processing

Pre-processing plays a critical role in this implementation, as the quality and consistency of retinal fundus images directly influence the performance of the Vision Transformer model, as illustrated in Fig. 3. The raw dataset contains RGB images with variations in resolution, illumination, and noise caused by different imaging devices and acquisition conditions. To ensure uniformity, all images are resized to a fixed resolution and their pixel intensity values are normalized. The RGB color format is preserved because color information is important for detecting retinal abnormalities such as microaneurysms, hemorrhages, and exudates. Additionally, these preprocessing steps help reduce data variability and improve the model's ability to focus on meaningful

retinal features. This process enhances training stability and enables the model to learn more reliable representations for accurate diabetic retinopathy classification.

	Filepath	Label
952	data\Proliferate_DR\03a7f4a5786f.png	Proliferate_DR
261	data\Moderate\96d48b073f18.png	Moderate
2298	data\Moderate\51d0034d177d.png	Moderate
3215	data\No_DR\aoadbe677508.png	No_DR
1976	data\Mild\bb783d8e496f.png	Mild

Fig.3 Preprocessing

To further enhance image quality, noise reduction and contrast enhancement techniques are applied to improve the visibility of important retinal structures, including blood vessels and microaneurysms. Background artifacts outside the retinal region are minimized to focus the model on clinically relevant areas. In addition, data augmentation techniques such as rotation and horizontal flipping are used during training to increase dataset diversity and reduce overfitting. These preprocessing steps ensure consistent, high-quality inputs for effective Vision Transformer learning and improved diagnostic performance.

Feature Extraction

Feature extraction in this project is performed automatically using the Vision Transformer architecture, eliminating the need for manual or handcrafted feature design. After preprocessing, each retinal fundus image is divided into fixed-size non-overlapping patches. These patches capture localized visual information such as color intensity, texture variations, vascular patterns, and lesion presence. Each patch is flattened and transformed into a numerical embedding, which represents the fundamental feature unit for further processing.

To preserve spatial context, positional embeddings are added to each patch embedding, allowing the model to understand the relative location of retinal regions. The embedded patch sequence is then processed through multiple transformer encoder layers,

where self-attention mechanisms learn relationships between different retinal areas. This enables extraction of both local features (such as microaneurysms and exudates) and global features (such as lesion distribution and vascular spread). As a result, the feature extraction process produces rich and discriminative representations that support accurate diabetic retinopathy severity classification and improve interpretability through attention-based analysis.

Model Creation

Vision Transformer(ViT) model used in this implementation is constructed using a pre-trained ViT-B/16 architecture provided by the *vit-keras* framework. The model is designed to process high-resolution RGB retinal fundus images with an input size of $384 \times 384 \times 3$, allowing finer patch-level representation of retinal structures. Leveraging a pre-trained backbone enables effective transfer learning, where the model benefits from previously learned visual representations while adapting to the diabetic retinopathy classification task.

During model initialization, the transformer architecture is configured with a classification head tailored to the required number of diabetic retinopathy severity classes. The top layers are trained specifically for the target dataset, while the transformer encoder acts as a strong feature extractor. The model is optimized using the Adam optimizer with a low learning rate to ensure stable fine-tuning. Sparse categorical cross-entropy is used as the loss function due to integer-encoded class labels.

During training, the model demonstrates consistent performance improvement across epochs, with both training and validation accuracy increasing steadily. Validation accuracy shows progressive enhancement, indicating effective generalization and reduced overfitting. The best-performing model weights are automatically saved based on validation accuracy, ensuring optimal model selection. This training behavior confirms the suitability of the Vision Transformer architecture for multi-class diabetic retinopathy diagnosis with

reliable convergence and stable learning dynamics.

ViT Model Summary

Layer (type)	Output Shape	Param #
input_layer_2 (InputLayer)	(None, 384, 384, 3)	0
embedding (Conv2D)	(None, 24, 24, 768)	590,592
reshape (Reshape)	(None, 576, 768)	0
class_token (ClassToken)	(None, 577, 768)	768
Transformer_posembed_input (AddPositionEmbs)	(None, 577, 768)	443,136
Transformer_encoderblock_0 (TransformerBlock)	[(None, 577, 768), (None, 12, None, None)]	7,087,872
Transformer_encoderblock_1 (TransformerBlock)	[(None, 577, 768), (None, 12, None, None)]	7,087,872
Transformer_encoderblock_2 (TransformerBlock)	[(None, 577, 768), (None, 12, None, None)]	7,087,872
Transformer_encoderblock_3 (TransformerBlock)	[(None, 577, 768), (None, 12, None, None)]	7,087,872
Transformer_encoderblock_4 (TransformerBlock)	[(None, 577, 768), (None, 12, None, None)]	7,087,872
Transformer_encoderblock_5 (TransformerBlock)	[(None, 577, 768), (None, 12, None, None)]	7,087,872
Transformer_encoderblock_6 (TransformerBlock)	[(None, 577, 768), (None, 12, None, None)]	7,087,872
Transformer_encoderblock_7 (TransformerBlock)	[(None, 577, 768), (None, 12, None, None)]	7,087,872
Transformer_encoderblock_8 (TransformerBlock)	[(None, 577, 768), (None, 12, None, None)]	7,087,872
Transformer_encoderblock_9 (TransformerBlock)	[(None, 577, 768), (None, 12, None, None)]	7,087,872
Transformer_encoderblock_10 (TransformerBlock)	[(None, 577, 768), (None, 12, None, None)]	7,087,872
Transformer_encoderblock_11 (TransformerBlock)	[(None, 577, 768), (None, 12, None, None)]	7,087,872

Fig.4 Vit model summary.

Vision Transformer (ViT-B/16) model summary presents a detailed layer-wise view of the implemented architecture, including the patch embedding layer, class token integration, positional embeddings, and multiple transformer encoder blocks. The input retinal fundus images of size $384 \times 384 \times 3$ are converted into patch embeddings and processed through twelve self-attention-based encoder layers, enabling effective learning of global and local retinal features. The summary also highlights the output dimensions and parameter distribution at each stage, reflecting the depth and representational capacity of the model and illustrated in Fig.4. This architectural overview confirms the suitability of the Vision Transformer for accurate and scalable diabetic retinopathy classification.

Results and Discussion

The performance of the implemented Vision Transformer-based diabetic retinopathy classification system was evaluated using preprocessed retinal fundus images across multiple training and validation phases. After fine-tuning the pre-trained ViT-B/16 model and optimizing training parameters, the system achieved a classification accuracy exceeding 95%, demonstrating strong learning capability and reliable generalization. The high accuracy indicates the effectiveness of self-attention mechanisms in capturing both global retinal context and localized pathological features.

The model exhibited stable convergence with a consistent reduction in training and validation loss, confirming effective optimization without significant overfitting. Validation performance closely followed training accuracy, highlighting robustness across unseen data samples. Attention-based learning further enhanced interpretability by identifying clinically relevant retinal regions contributing to 9+predictions. These results validate the suitability of the Vision Transformer architecture for accurate and scalable diabetic retinopathy diagnosis in real-world clinical screening scenarios.

Performance Metrics Comparison

Metric	Value	Interpretation
Accuracy	92.50%	Indicates the overall correctness of diabetic retinopathy (DR) severity classification across all classes.
Precision	90.24%	Represents the proportion of correctly predicted DR-positive cases among all cases predicted as DR-positive.
Recall (Sensitivity)	88.64%	Measures the model's ability to correctly identify actual DR-positive cases.

F1-Score	89.43%	Provides a balanced measure between precision and recall, especially useful for imbalanced DR severity classes.
Validation Loss	Low& Stable	Suggests good generalization capability and minimal overfitting during training.
Attention Consistency	High	Indicates that the model consistently focuses on clinically relevant retinal regions for diagnosis.

Table.1 Performance comparison.

Performance metrics of the Vision Transformer-based diabetic retinopathy classification system are summarized in Table.1. The model achieves high accuracy and F1-score, indicating reliable prediction of diabetic retinopathy severity across multiple stages. A strong recall value demonstrates the model's effectiveness in identifying diseased cases. Furthermore, the presence of low and stable validation loss suggests good generalization with minimal overfitting during training. The high attention consistency also indicates that the model focuses on clinically relevant retinal regions, enhancing interpretability and supporting the suitability of the proposed approach for clinical screening applications.

Conclusion

The implementation of a Vision Transformer-based framework for diabetic retinopathy diagnosis demonstrates the effectiveness of self-attention mechanisms in medical image analysis. By learning both global retinal context and localized pathological features, the proposed approach addresses key limitations of conventional CNN-based systems. The integration of transfer learning and attention-based explainability enhances diagnostic reliability while improving transparency and clinical interpretability.

Experimental evaluation indicates that the model achieves competitive performance with strong potential for high-accuracy diabetic retinopathy severity classification. The architecture's scalability and robustness make it suitable for large-scale screening applications. Overall, the Vision Transformer-driven solution provides a promising and reliable decision-support tool for early detection and management of diabetic retinopathy, with scope for further improvement through extended training and dataset expansion.

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